

JJ SCHOOL OF ART, MUMBAI

CREATIVE CONNECT



Under a sprawling neem tree, over cups of hot tea at Ramayya's Canteen, creativity flows unbridled; and the 1,000 students at Sir JJ School of Art spend hours painting, sketching and sculpting. Walk into the consecrated walls of India's first art school and the rich artistic history envelops you. Founded in 1857 by Sir Jamsetjee Jeejeebhoy through an endowment of Rs 1 lakh, today the institute is divided into departments of commercial art, fine art, sculptural modelling and teacher's training. The first classes in architecture were started in 1900 at the school under the guidance of John Begg, the first consulting architect to the government of Bombay.

From expert architect and sculptor Lockwood Kipling (writer Rudyard's father) who taught here, to painters such as Francis

Newton Souza and M.F. Husain, the school has a rich legacy that derives strength from its several thousand alumni. Despite priceless art lying unattended and parts of the school in abject disrepair, these walls continue to witness the making of great artists and even greater art. "Our constant effort is to encourage art and craft that emerges from the hinterlands of the country," says director, Ravindra Balapure. No wonder, it remains one of the best the country has. Art historian Yashodhara Dalmia says it has been a pivotal force for masters such as Souza, Husain and even later artists such as Atul Dodiya, spanning generations and genres.

by Swati Mathur

1947

was the year when the Progressive Artists' group was founded by alumni S.H. Raza, K.H. Ara, H.G. Gade, M.F. Husain and Sadanand Bakre. India was introduced to modernism in Indian art for the very first time.

"The greatest strength of the institute has been its alumni, who have set unmatched standards." RAVINDRA BALAPURE, DIRECTOR, JJ SCHOOL OF ART



ARTISTIC EDGE: Balapure standing beside a sculpture by N.G. Pansare

SHRIYA PATIL SHINDE